WEEK 2: UNDERSTANDING YOUR CYCLE & TRIGGERS

The CSBD Cycle in Detail

Last week you learned the four stages of the addiction cycle. This week, we're going deeper into your personal version of that cycle.

THE GOAL: If you can recognize where you are in the cycle, you can interrupt it before reaching the acting out stage.

Most men can stop the cycle in the preoccupation stage with moderate effort. Some can still stop during ritualization, but it's much harder. Once you're in the acting out stage, stopping requires enormous willpower—and often fails. Once you're in despair, you've already set up the next cycle.

Early intervention is everything.

STAGE 1: PREOCCUPATION

This is where the cycle begins. Your mind becomes increasingly focused on sexual thoughts, fantasies, or planning.

What it looks like:

- Repetitive thoughts about sex, pornography, or specific sexual behaviors
- Mental rehearsal or fantasy (playing out scenarios in your mind)
- Planning: when, where, how you'll act out
- Difficulty concentrating on work, conversation, or other tasks
- Feeling "zoned out" or in a trance-like state
- Increasing restlessness, anxiety, or agitation
- A sense of building tension that "needs" release

What you might notice physically:

- Tension in your chest, jaw, or shoulders
- Restlessness—inability to sit still
- Increased heart rate

- A feeling of being "wound up" or "on edge"
- Difficulty making eye contact or being present with others

What triggers preoccupation:

- Stress or overwhelming emotions
- Boredom or lack of meaningful activity
- Relationship conflict or fears about intimacy
- Unmet emotional needs (connection, validation, excitement)
- Exposure to sexual cues (images, ads, memories)
- Fatigue or physical depletion
- Success or failure (both can trigger)

How long it lasts: For some men, preoccupation lasts hours or days. For others, it moves quickly into ritualization within minutes.

STAGE 2: RITUALIZATION

Ritualization is the bridge between thinking about the behavior and actually doing it. These are the preparatory steps that lead directly to acting out.

What it looks like:

- Opening your browser in incognito or private mode
- Driving toward a location where you typically act out
- Checking to see if you're alone or will have privacy
- Arranging your schedule to create opportunity
- "Just checking" certain websites, apps, or locations
- Ensuring you have time, money, or means
- Creating the conditions that enable the behavior
- Telling yourself "I'm just looking" or "I won't actually do it"

Why this stage is critical:

For most men, once ritualization begins, the behavior becomes extremely difficult to stop. The rituals create momentum. Your brain is already releasing dopamine in anticipation. Your arousal is building. Your rational thinking is decreasing.

Recognizing your specific rituals gives you an earlier intervention point—before the point of no return.

How long it lasts: Ritualization can be very brief (opening a browser tab) or extended (driving across town). The length doesn't matter—what matters is recognizing it's happening.

STAGE 3: ACTING OUT

This is the sexual behavior itself. What this looks like varies significantly from person to person:

Common behaviors:

- Viewing pornography (often for hours)
- Compulsive masturbation (multiple times per day)
- Hiring sex workers or escorts
- Anonymous sexual encounters (apps, bathhouses, rest stops, public places)
- Visiting strip clubs, massage parlors, or adult stores
- Excessive use of dating or hookup apps
- Voyeuristic behavior (watching others without consent)
- Exhibitionism (exposing yourself to others)
- Sexting or online sexual chat
- Any other sexual behavior done compulsively despite negative consequences

What it feels like in the moment:

- Temporary relief from anxiety, stress, or emotional pain
- Brief pleasure or excitement (though often less than anticipated)
- Numbness or escape from difficult emotions
- A sense of physical and emotional release
- Tunnel vision—nothing else matters, consequences disappear
- Dissociation from reality (feeling like you're watching yourself from outside your body)
- Time distortion (hours feel like minutes)
- A feeling of inevitability ("I can't stop now")

What happens during acting out:

- Rational thinking is offline
- You're in a trance-like state
- Promises and consequences feel distant and unreal
- The behavior often escalates (more time, more extreme content, more risk)

STAGE 4: DESPAIR

After acting out, reality crashes back in. The shame cycle begins almost immediately.

What it looks like:

- Intense shame and self-hatred
- Guilt about broken promises (to yourself, to God, to your partner)
- Fear of being discovered or exposed
- Promises to "never do it again" (that feel genuine in the moment)
- Feeling hopeless about the possibility of change
- Isolation and hiding from others
- Depression, anxiety, or emotional numbness
- Self-punishment or harsh negative self-talk
- Sometimes: anger at yourself or others

Physical sensations:

- Exhaustion or fatigue
- Emptiness or hollowness
- Physical shame (difficulty looking in mirror, feeling "dirty")
- Loss of appetite or compulsive eating

The duration: Despair can last hours, days, or even weeks. For some men, it's brief before the cycle starts again. For others, it lingers.

The cruel trap: This despair creates the exact uncomfortable emotions (shame, anxiety, hopelessness, disconnection) that trigger the next cycle.

You feel terrible → You need escape → You return to the behavior that makes you feel terrible → More shame → More need for escape → The cycle continues.

THE SELF-PERPETUATING CYCLE

Here's why this cycle is so difficult to break on your own:

```
DESPAIR
  ↓
Shame, anxiety, hopelessness
  ↓
PREOCCUPATION (escape through fantasy)
  ↓
Relief from negative emotions
  ↓
RITUALIZATION (momentum builds)
  ↓
Arousal increases, rational thinking decreases
  ↓
ACTING OUT (temporary relief)
  ↓
Brief satisfaction, then reality returns
  ↓
DESPAIR (shame intensifies)
  ↓
[Cycle repeats, often faster and with more intensity]
```

The cycle feeds itself. Each stage creates the conditions for the next stage.

Breaking the cycle requires intervening EARLY—ideally catching yourself in preoccupation, before rituals begin. Once you're in ritualization, it's much harder. Once you're acting out, it's nearly impossible. Once you're in despair, you're already setting up the next cycle.

Your goal over the next 16 weeks: Learn to recognize where you are in the cycle and interrupt it at the earliest possible point.

EXERCISE 1: MAPPING MY PERSONAL CYCLE

Now it's time to map YOUR specific cycle. This is not a generic exercise—this is about understanding your unique patterns.

Be as detailed and specific as possible. The more you understand your cycle, the more power you have to interrupt it.

MY PREOCCUPATION STAGE

What thoughts typically start the cycle for me?

_____

_____

_____

What does my preoccupation feel like physically? (tension, restlessness, arousal, etc.)

_____

_____

What emotions am I usually feeling when preoccupation begins?

_____

_____

How long does preoccupation usually last before I move to ritualization?

_____

What time of day does preoccupation most often occur?

_____

Can I recognize when preoccupation is starting, or does it feel like it's already happening before I notice?

_____

_____

_____

MY RITUALIZATION STAGE

What are my specific rituals? (List EVERY preparatory behavior, even the small ones)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____

At what point in my rituals does it feel "too late" to stop?

What do I tell myself during ritualization? ("I'm just checking," "I won't actually do it," etc.)

What physical changes happen during ritualization? (arousal, heart rate, breathing, etc.)

MY ACTING OUT STAGE

What specific behaviors do I engage in?

How long does acting out typically last?

Does the behavior escalate during acting out? (more time, more extreme, more risky)

What am I trying to FEEL during acting out?

What am I trying NOT to feel during acting out?

What does the behavior give me, even temporarily?

MY DESPAIR STAGE

What emotions do I feel immediately after acting out?

_____

_____

What do I tell myself about myself?

_____

_____

What physical sensations do I notice? (exhaustion, emptiness, shame in body, etc.)

_____

_____

How long does despair typically last?

_____

What behaviors do I engage in during despair? (isolation, self-punishment, eating, sleeping, etc.)

_____

_____

What usually ends the despair stage and starts the cycle again?

_____

_____

_____

Understanding Triggers

A **trigger** is anything—internal or external—that starts the cycle by activating preoccupation.

Most men have predictable triggers, but they don't recognize them until they start paying close attention.

The key insight: If you can identify your triggers, you can prepare for them and interrupt the cycle before it even begins.

EXTERNAL TRIGGERS (Things Outside of You)

PEOPLE:

Certain people or types of interactions can trigger the cycle:

- Arguments with partner or spouse

- Rejection or criticism from anyone
- Partner being away or unavailable
- Feeling ignored, invisible, or unimportant
- Social anxiety or pressure
- Seeing attractive people (in person, on screens, in ads)
- Interactions that leave you feeling inadequate

PLACES:

Certain locations are associated with acting out or create opportunity:

- Being alone at home
- Hotels or business travel
- Certain routes you drive (past strip clubs, massage parlors, etc.)
- Places associated with past acting out
- Environments where you feel anonymous
- Your car (privacy, downtime)
- Bathroom at work or home

THINGS:

Certain objects or substances lower inhibition or create access:

- Smartphone (access + privacy)
- Computer/laptop (especially when alone)
- TV/streaming (sexual content in media)
- Alcohol (lowers inhibition)
- Other substances (marijuana, stimulants, etc.)
- Money or credit cards (access to paid sexual services)
- Free time or unstructured hours

SITUATIONS:

Certain circumstances create vulnerability:

- High stress at work or home

- Financial pressure or money problems
- Too much free time or boredom
- Success or celebration ("I deserve a reward")
- Failure or disappointment ("I need comfort")
- After attempting intimacy with partner (especially if it didn't go well)
- Holidays or family gatherings
- Transitions (job change, move, life milestone)

HALT STATES:

This acronym captures four common physiological triggers:

- **H**ungry: Poor nutrition, skipped meals, low blood sugar
- **A**ngry: Resentment, frustration, unresolved conflict
- **L**onely: Isolation, disconnection, lack of meaningful contact
- **T**ired: Poor sleep, exhaustion, physical depletion

When you're in one or more HALT states, you're significantly more vulnerable to acting out.

INTERNAL TRIGGERS (Things Inside of You)

EMOTIONS:

Certain feelings consistently trigger the cycle:

- **Anxiety or fear:** About work, relationships, health, future
- **Anger or resentment:** At partner, boss, self, situation
- **Sadness or depression:** Feeling hopeless, empty, or down
- **Loneliness or disconnection:** Feeling isolated even around people
- **Boredom or restlessness:** Lack of engagement or purpose
- **Shame or inadequacy:** Feeling "less than" or fundamentally flawed
- **Excitement or pride:** Positive emotions can also trigger (reward mindset)
- **Overwhelm:** Too much on your plate, can't cope

Important: Both negative AND positive emotions can trigger. It's not just about feeling bad—it's about any strong emotion you haven't learned to process.

THOUGHTS:

Certain thought patterns give you permission to act out:

- "I deserve this" (entitlement)
- "Just this once won't hurt" (minimization)
- "I've already messed up, might as well continue" (all-or-nothing thinking)
- "I can't handle this feeling" (low distress tolerance)
- "No one will know" (secrecy)
- "I'll start recovery tomorrow" (delay)
- "This isn't that bad compared to..." (comparison)
- "I need this to function" (perceived necessity)

These are called **permission-giving thoughts** or **cognitive distortions**. We'll work on challenging them in Week 3.

PHYSICAL SENSATIONS:

Certain body states increase vulnerability:

- Fatigue or exhaustion
- Physical tension (tight shoulders, jaw, chest)
- Sexual arousal (from any source—dreams, random, media)
- Restlessness or inability to sit still
- Physical pain or discomfort
- Hunger or blood sugar crashes

EXERCISE 2: MY TRIGGER INVENTORY

Use the checklist below to identify your personal triggers.

Instructions:

- Check ALL that apply

- Be honest—this is for you, not anyone else
- Add your own triggers in the "Other" spaces
- Circle or highlight your TOP 5 most powerful triggers

EXTERNAL TRIGGERS

PEOPLE (check all that apply):

- ☐ Arguments with partner/spouse
- ☐ Rejection or criticism from anyone
- ☐ Partner being away/unavailable
- ☐ Feeling ignored or invisible
- ☐ Social pressure or anxiety
- ☐ Seeing attractive people
- ☐ Feeling judged or evaluated
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

PLACES:

- ☐ Home alone
- ☐ Hotels/travel
- ☐ Specific location: _____
- ☐ My car
- ☐ Work environment
- ☐ Bathroom
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

THINGS:

- ☐ Smartphone
- ☐ Computer/laptop
- ☐ TV/streaming
- ☐ Alcohol
- ☐ Marijuana or other substances
- ☐ Money/credit cards
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

SITUATIONS:

- ☐ Work stress
- ☐ Financial pressure
- ☐ Too much free time
- ☐ Boredom
- ☐ Success/celebration
- ☐ Failure/disappointment
- ☐ After attempted intimacy with partner
- ☐ Holidays or family events
- ☐ Transitions (job, move, etc.)
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

HALT STATES (check all that frequently apply):

- ☐ **H**ungry (poor nutrition, skipped meals)
- ☐ **A**ngry (resentment, frustration, unresolved conflict)
- ☐ **L**onely (isolated, disconnected, lacking meaningful contact)
- ☐ **T**ired (poor sleep, exhaustion, physical depletion)

INTERNAL TRIGGERS

EMOTIONS (check all that apply):

- ☐ Anxiety
- ☐ Anger
- ☐ Sadness
- ☐ Loneliness
- ☐ Boredom
- ☐ Shame
- ☐ Inadequacy
- ☐ Fear
- ☐ Excitement
- ☐ Overwhelm
- ☐ Numbness
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

THOUGHTS:

- [ ] "I deserve this"
- [ ] "Just this once"
- [ ] "I've already messed up"
- [ ] "I can't handle this feeling"
- [ ] "No one will know"
- [ ] "I'll start tomorrow"
- [ ] "This isn't that bad"
- [ ] "I need this to function"
- [ ] Other: _____
- [ ] Other: _____

PHYSICAL SENSATIONS:

- [ ] Fatigue
- [ ] Physical tension
- [ ] Sexual arousal
- [ ] Restlessness
- [ ] Physical pain
- [ ] Hunger
- [ ] Other: _____
- [ ] Other: _____

MY TOP 5 TRIGGERS

Based on the checklist above, identify your five most common or powerful triggers. These are the ones that almost always lead to acting out if you don't intervene.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

The Function of Sexual Behavior: What Need Is It Meeting?

Here's a critical insight most men miss:

Sexual behavior isn't random. It serves a function.

Even destructive behavior is an attempt to meet a legitimate need—it's just meeting that need in a way that causes harm.

Understanding what need your sexual behavior is trying to meet helps you find healthier ways to meet that same need.

COMMON FUNCTIONS OF COMPULSIVE SEXUAL BEHAVIOR:

1. STRESS RELIEF

- Temporary escape from overwhelming pressure
- Physical release of built-up tension
- Numbing of difficult emotions
- "Turning off" an overactive mind

2. EMOTIONAL REGULATION

- Managing anxiety, anger, sadness
- Creating positive feelings when lacking them
- Avoiding uncomfortable emotions
- Self-soothing when distressed

3. CONNECTION (even if artificial)

- Substitute for authentic intimacy
- Feeling desired, wanted, or attractive
- Reducing loneliness (even though it's not real connection)
- Fantasy of being known and accepted

4. EXCITEMENT

- Dopamine hit when life feels boring or monotonous
- Novelty and stimulation
- Risk and danger (activating your nervous system)
- Breaking the routine

5. POWER OR CONTROL

- Feeling in control when life feels chaotic
- Sense of power, dominance, or agency
- Rebellion against restrictions (partner, society, self-imposed rules)
- Reclaiming autonomy

6. SELF-MEDICATION

- Treating underlying depression without antidepressants
- Managing anxiety without therapy or medication
- Coping with trauma or PTSD symptoms
- Managing ADHD symptoms (stimulation, focus, dopamine)

7. VALIDATION OR WORTH

- Proving you're attractive or desirable
- Feeling "successful" in some domain
- Counteracting feelings of inadequacy
- Temporary boost to self-esteem

EXERCISE 3: WHAT FUNCTION DOES MY BEHAVIOR SERVE?

Take time to honestly reflect on what your sexual behavior is trying to accomplish. What need is it attempting to meet?

When I engage in compulsive sexual behavior, what am I trying to GET?

What am I trying to FEEL?

_____

_____

_____

What am I trying to EXPERIENCE?

_____

_____

_____

_____

When I engage in compulsive sexual behavior, what am I trying to AVOID?

What am I trying NOT to feel?

_____

_____

_____

What am I trying to ESCAPE from?

_____

_____

_____

_____

What legitimate need is this behavior attempting to meet?

(Circle all that apply)

Stress relief | Emotional regulation | Connection | Excitement | Power/Control | Self-medication | Validation | Other: _____

_____

If I couldn't use sexual behavior, how else might I meet this need in a healthier way?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

SKILL: PAUSE AND OBSERVE

This week you're learning a simple but powerful technique: **Pause and Observe.**

This is a foundational mindfulness skill that creates space between trigger and response—the space where choice lives.

HOW IT WORKS:

When you notice an urge, a trigger, or the beginning of preoccupation, instead of immediately reacting or trying to make it go away:

1. PAUSE (even for just 10 seconds)

- Stop what you're doing
- Take three slow, deep breaths
- Create space between trigger and automatic response

2. OBSERVE (without judgment)

- What am I feeling right now?
- What am I thinking right now?
- What do I notice in my body?
- What triggered this urge or thought?

3. NAME IT (label the experience)

- "I'm feeling anxious"
- "I'm having an urge"
- "I'm noticing tension in my chest"
- "I'm in preoccupation"

That's it.

You don't have to fix it. You don't have to make it go away. You don't have to act on it. You just pause and observe.

This simple practice does three powerful things:

1. **Activates your prefrontal cortex** (your rational brain, your "brake")
2. **Creates awareness** (you can't change what you don't notice)
3. **Interrupts automaticity** (breaks the pattern of trigger → immediate action)

PRACTICE INSTRUCTIONS:

This week, practice Pause and Observe twice daily:

Morning Practice (when you wake up or after coffee)

- Set a phone alarm as a reminder
- Sit quietly for 60 seconds

- Pause and observe: What am I feeling? What am I thinking? What do I notice in my body?
- Write down what you noticed

Evening Practice (before bed)

- Set a phone alarm as a reminder
- Sit quietly for 60 seconds
- Pause and observe: What am I feeling? What am I thinking? What do I notice in my body?
- Write down what you noticed

Bonus: Practice in the moment

- When you notice an urge, pause and observe before doing anything else
- When you notice a trigger, pause and observe
- When you catch yourself in preoccupation, pause and observe

The goal is NOT to make urges go away. The goal is to BUILD AWARENESS.

PAUSE AND OBSERVE PRACTICE LOG

Track your practice this week. Consistency matters more than intensity.

Day	Morning Practice (Y/N)	Evening Practice (Y/N)	What I Noticed
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

At the end of the week, reflect:

How did this practice feel?

What was most challenging about it?

Did I notice any changes in my awareness or reactivity?

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 2

Continue your daily monitoring. Use the same format as Week 1.

Remember to track:

- Stress level and sleep
- HALT states
- Number and intensity of urges
- Triggers you noticed
- Whether you engaged in problematic behavior
- Coping strategies used
- Emotions experienced
- What you learned

[7 daily logs with same format as Week 1—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 2 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 3, complete:

- [ ] Complete personal cycle mapping exercise
- [ ] Complete trigger inventory checklist
- [ ] Identify top 5 triggers
- [ ] Reflect on function of behavior (what need it meets)
- [ ] Practice Pause and Observe twice daily for 7 days
- [ ] Complete Pause and Observe practice log
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days

- [ ] Notice: What emotions precede urges this week?
- [ ] Begin preparing for Week 3: Notice your automatic thoughts

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Notes for Week 2:

END OF WEEK 2